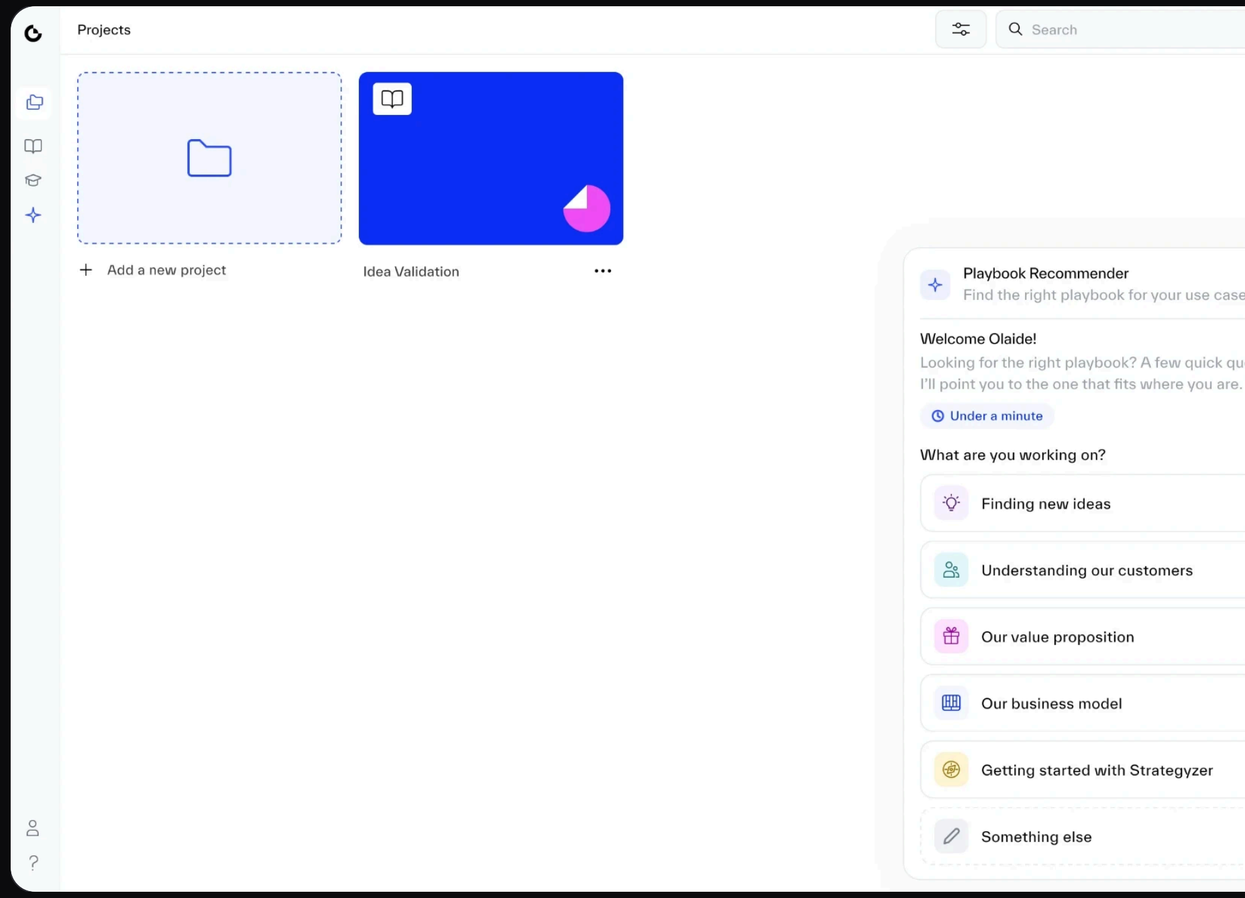
Solving the first-step problem

We set out to build an AI assistant. I made the case to ship a three-question Playbook Recommender first.

57% → 85%

of new customers now start a project and a playbook



ROLE
Senior product designer, and the only designer

TEAM
Head of Product, one engineer, coaching and customer teams

TIMELINE
About 6 weeks, spring 2026

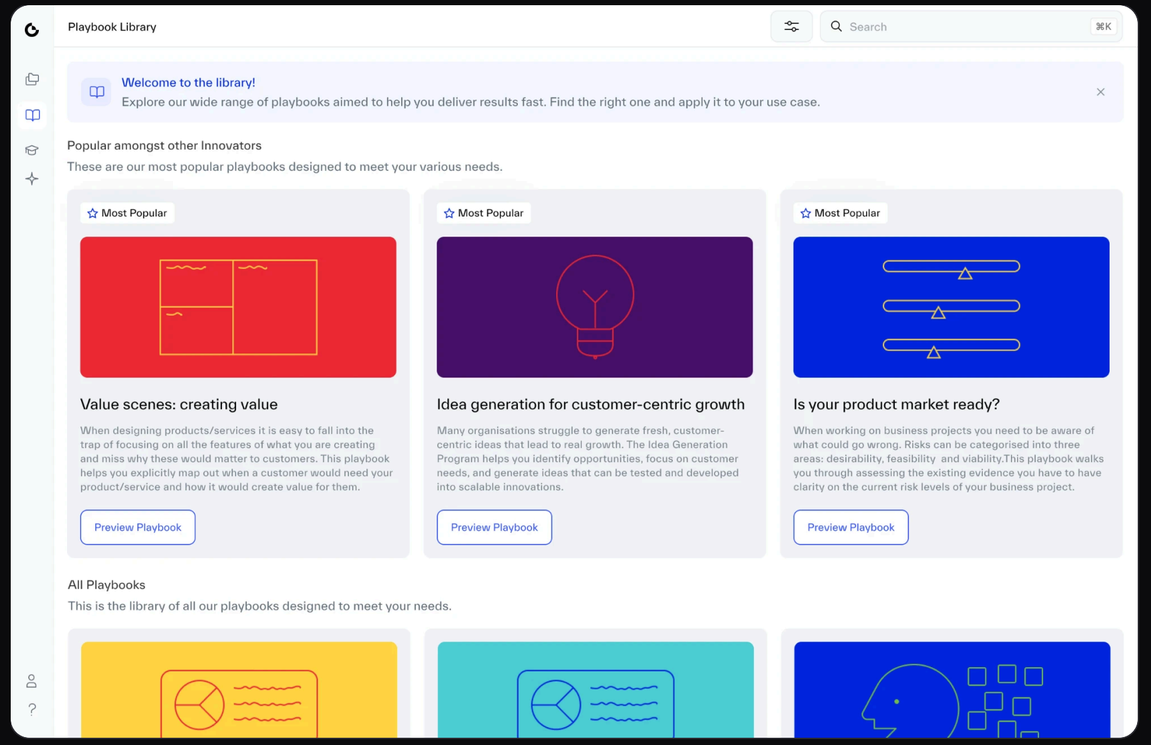
STATUS
Live

New customers got stuck on their first choice.

43%

of new customers never started a project.

ENTERPRISE	A coach asks two or three questions, then says start here.
SELF-SERVE	The full library, chosen alone, just when they know the least.



What a self-serve customer saw first. Long descriptions, then the whole library.

Even our own coaches found choosing a playbook hard.

It was the most common complaint in every conversation. So the problem was in the product.

8

customer interviews, plus our customer success and coaching teams

GROUP ONE

Solo founders

Testing an idea before pitching investors

GROUP TWO

Heads of strategy and innovation

Testing an idea before presenting to senior leaders

THE SAME PROBLEM

- Too many ideas
- No clear first step
- An important meeting coming up

Customers were asking for AI, so we started there.

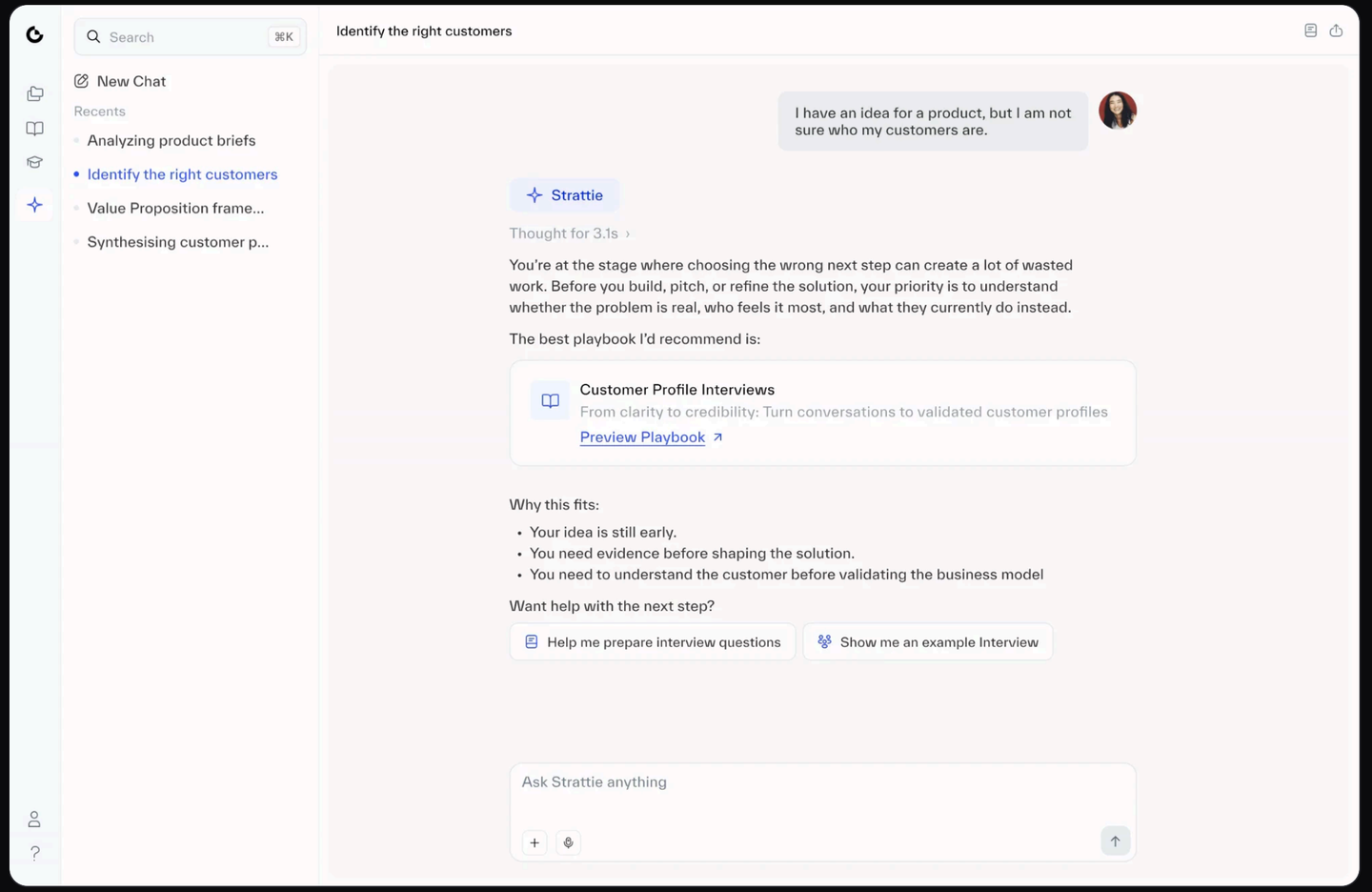
STRATTIE AI

An assistant across the whole platform, like a Strategyzer coach beside you. I designed it and built a working prototype with Claude.

A coach you could chat with

Help on the canvas

Playbook recommendations, one job of many



The full assistant, fully prototyped. Not in the first release.

Chat was the wrong tool for "where do I start?"

01

The value was in the questions.

A good coach asks two or three first. The open chat often answered before asking.

02

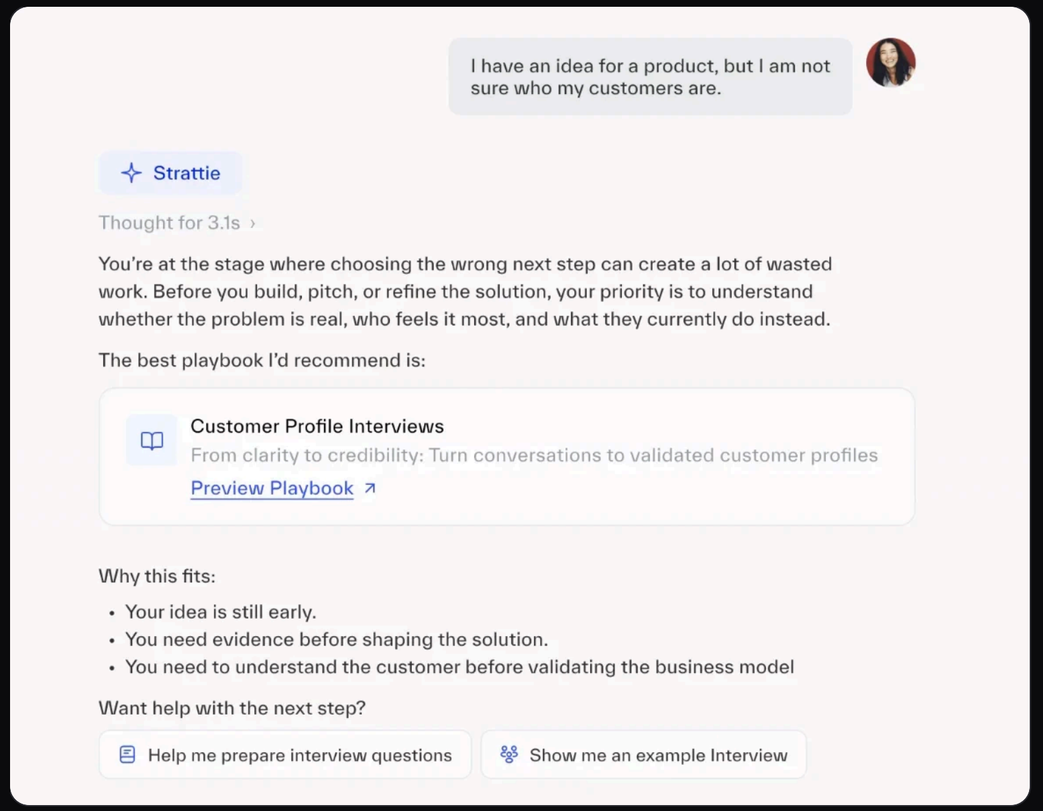
Doing it well was a much bigger job.

More than our small team could take on at the time.

03

People couldn't put their problem into words.

A chat box asks them to do exactly that.



The prototype. One message in, and it already recommends a playbook.

Engineering couldn't build the full assistant in time. The team's first instinct, a fair one, was a smaller version of it.

I pushed back. A smaller chatbot is just a worse chatbot.

	SMALLER CHATBOT	GUIDED RECOMMENDER
Designing the conversation	Still needed in full	■ A few fixed questions
Recommending playbooks that don't exist	Still possible	■ Not possible
Describing the problem	People have to type it	■ People pick from options
Shows whether guidance helps	Not clearly	■ Yes

SO I CHANGED THE QUESTION

~~What's the smallest assistant we can build?~~

What's the one job that matters most right now?

Every time, the answer was finding the right playbook.

MADE THE CASE TO

Our CEO and Head of Product, with the working prototype and my research.

THE PUSHBACK

Customers wanted AI. Guided questions could look like falling behind.

MY ANSWER

If people get stuck choosing, they'll leave before they ever see an AI feature.

DECISION **Ship the Recommender first. The assistant comes next.**

A trade-off, made knowingly.

■ WHAT IT BOUGHT US

Only real playbooks

I'd rather ship one job done well than several half-done.

Honest when nothing fits

Three taps instead of typing

Proof that guidance helps, first

WHAT IT COST · MOVED TO A LATER RELEASE

The full assistant

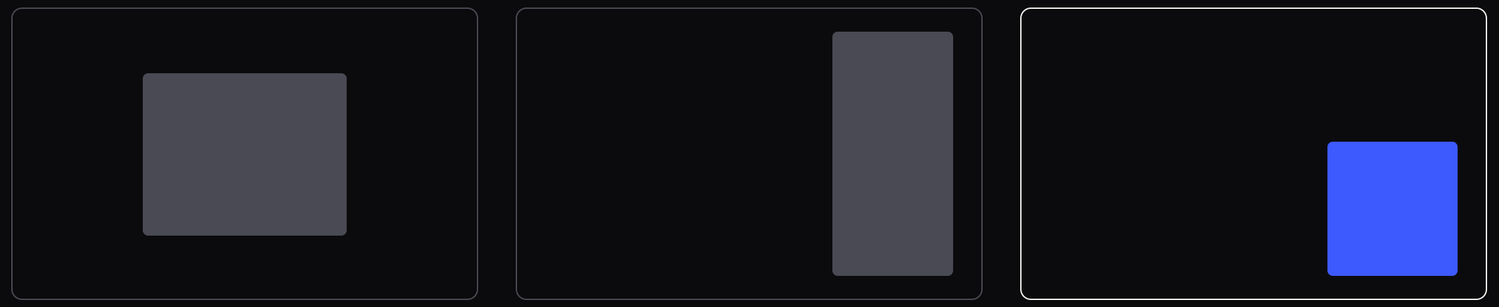
Help on the canvas

The chat panel

The onboarding tour

A small panel in the corner, built to come back to.

THREE SHAPES, TRIED AS WORKING FLOWS



Pop-up in the middle

Covered the library

Tall side panel

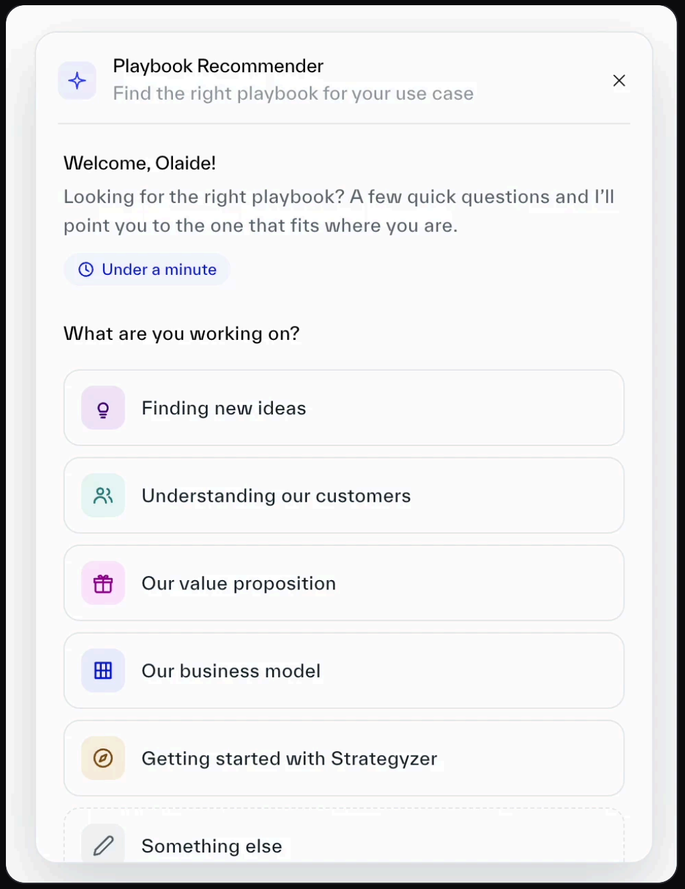
Looked like a chat that wasn't there

Small corner panel

Kept the page usable

Answers shrink as you go, so the panel stays short.

No tour. People return whenever they're stuck.



Shipped. Three questions to a recommendation.

A question map, built by hand from customer research.

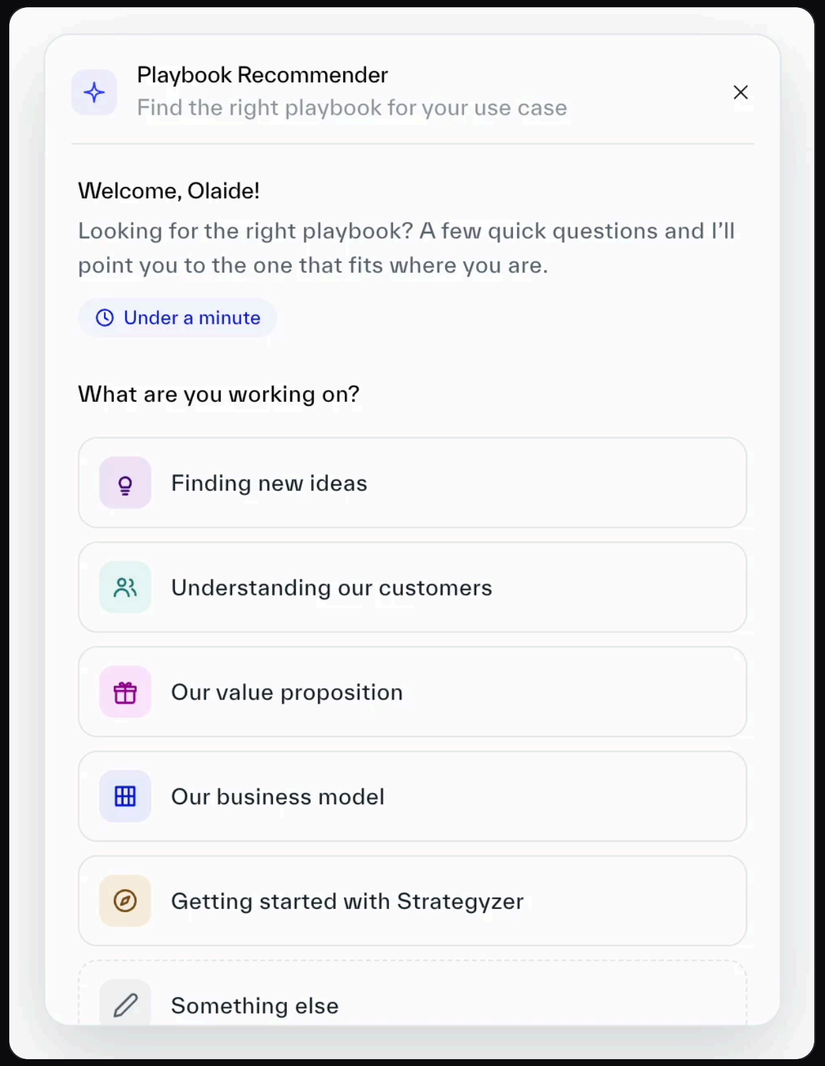
5 PROBLEM AREAS → **17** GOALS → **45** PATHS → **19** PLAYBOOKS

Written down, so we can trust it and fix it when it's wrong.

Question three only appears when it changes the answer.

IT ALSO FOUND A GAP

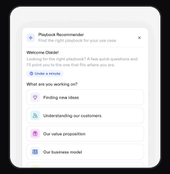
No playbook helped people test whether customers want their offer. The playbook team started on one straight away.



When nothing fits, it says so.

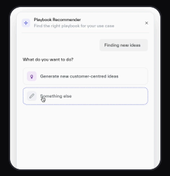
It shows the closest options instead of guessing. The hardest call in the project.

THREE MORE DETAILS THAT BUILD TRUST



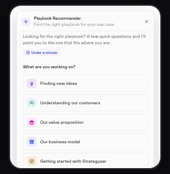
The panel stays the same size

No jumping as answers change.



Change an answer without starting over

Click any earlier answer to edit it.



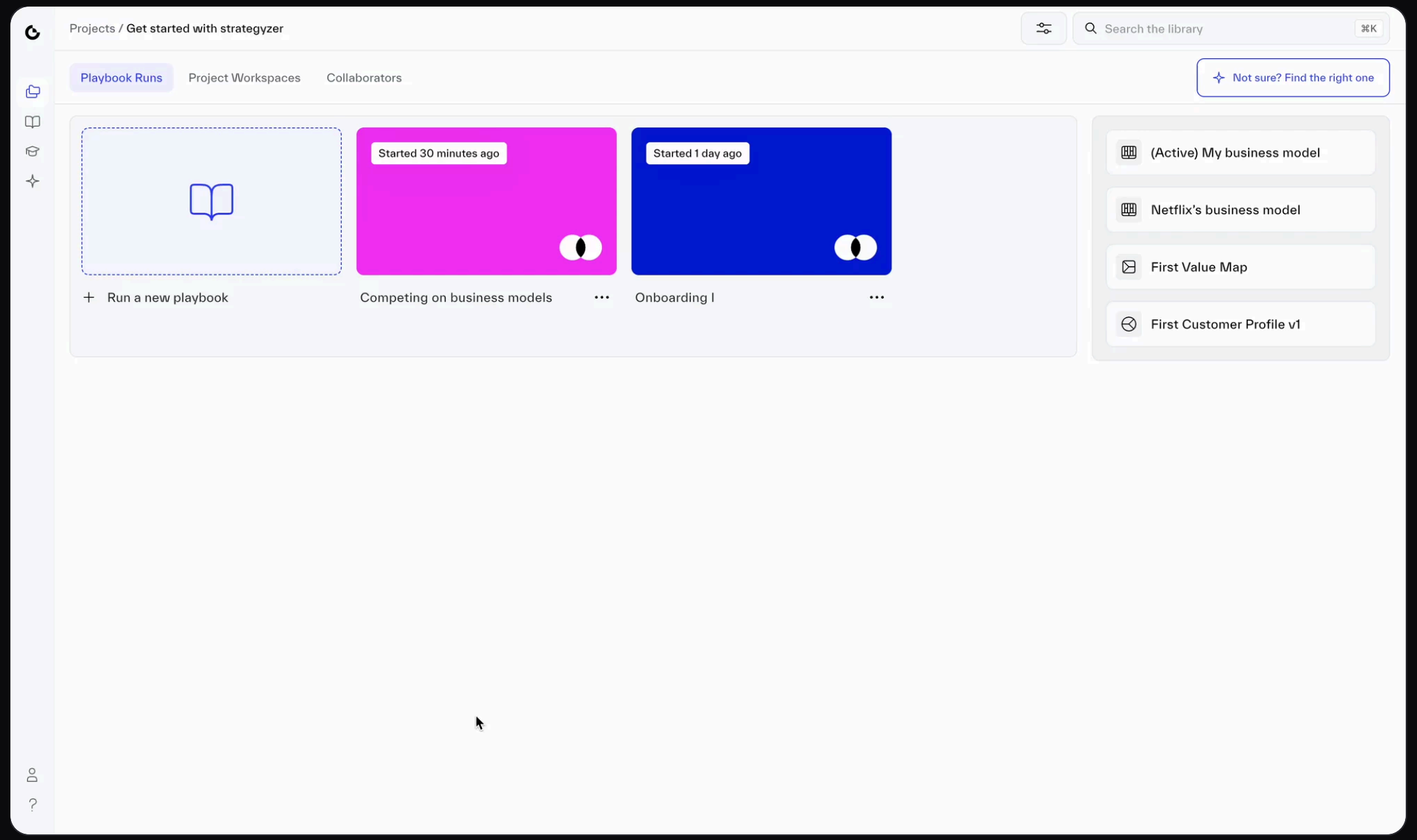
"Something else" in your own words

AI finds the closest real playbooks.

FROM STUCK TO STARTED

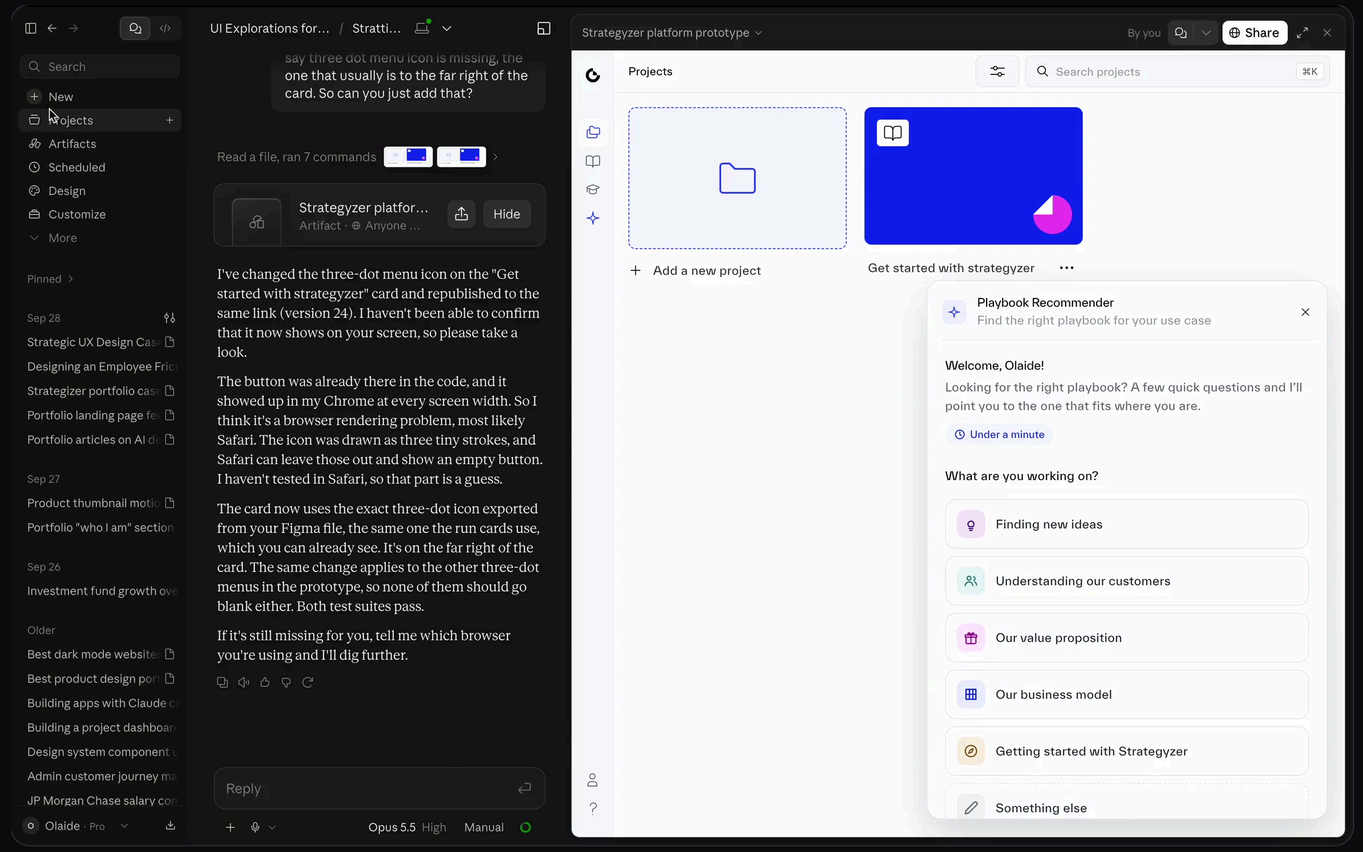
about **15** seconds

- STUCK
- QUESTION 1
- QUESTION 2
- QUESTION 3
- **STARTED**



One click on Add to this project, and the playbook starts.

Tested on the real product, shipped as it was.



My conversation with Claude on the left, the working front end on the right.

about **24**

test sessions with coaches, customer teams and customers

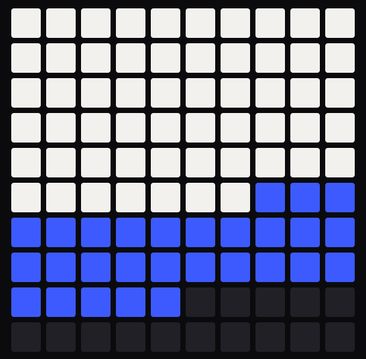
ME	The front end, built in code with Claude
OUR ENGINEER	Data, tracking and the platform connection

The team now works at least twice as fast.

Fixing the first step moved every number that mattered.

Four months of data, before and after launch.

GETTING STARTED

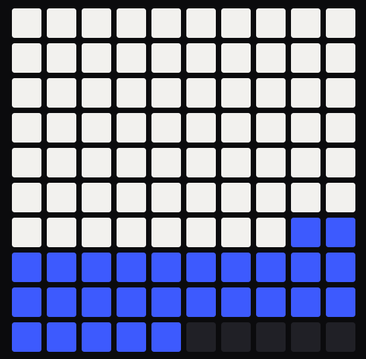


85%

was **57%**

of new customers start a project and a playbook

SATISFACTION

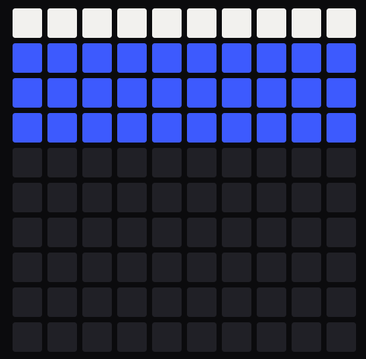


95%

was **68%**

from surveys and our customer success team

COMING BACK · 4×



40%

was **about 10%**

return within 30 days, most of them weekly

CANCELLED, THEN RETURNED



about 18%

after the release email

of cancelled customers came back to try it within two weeks

How we measured: product data for getting started and coming back, customer surveys and feedback for satisfaction

Next, the full assistant.

I've recommended building Strattie AI to help at every step after the first. It's on the roadmap for next year, and it can reuse the question map.



FIRST STEP · RECOMMENDER, LIVE

EVERY STEP AFTER · STRATTIE AI, ON THE ROADMAP

Shipping one focused thing first didn't shrink the vision. It made the case for it.